

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Ex-FBI chief indicted on 2 counts

Charges filed days after Trump urged prosecution of foes

By Eric Tucker and Alanna Durkin Richer
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — James Comey was charged Thursday with making a false statement and obstruction in a criminal case filed days after President Donald Trump appeared to urge his attorney general to prosecute the former FBI director and other perceived political enemies.

The indictment makes Comey the first former senior govern-

ment official to face prosecution in connection with one of Trump's chief grievances: the long-concluded investigation into Russian interference in the 2016 election. Trump and his supporters have long derided that investigation as a "hoax" and a "witch hunt" despite multiple government reviews showing Moscow interfered on behalf of the Republican's campaign.

The two-count indictment includes charges of making a false statement to Congress during

testimony five years ago as well as obstruction of a criminal proceeding.

The criminal case is likely to deepen concerns that the Justice Department under Attorney General Pam Bondi, a Trump loyalist, is being weaponized in pursuit of investigations and now prosecutions of public figures the president regards as his political enemies. It was filed as the White House has taken steps to exert influence in unprecedented ways on the operations of the Justice Department,

blurring the line between law and politics for an agency where independence in prosecutorial decision-making is a foundational principle.

Comey was fired months into Trump's first administration and has long been a top target for Trump supporters seeking retribution. Comey was singled out in a Saturday social media post in which Trump complained directly to Bondi that she had not yet brought charges against him.

The following evening, Trump said in a Truth Social post aimed

Turn to Comey, Page 7



Former FBI Director James Comey is sworn in before a Senate panel in Washington. DOUG MILLS/ THE NEW YORK TIMES 2017



Travaris "Breezy" Brown, left, and Marcus "Bully" Simpson, anti-violence outreach workers from the Institute for Nonviolence Chicago, visit locations on the West Side of Chicago on Sept. 19. TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

With eye on city's violence, Austin still awaits progress

Since 2022, the level of killings in the mayor's neighborhood has been relatively stagnant

By Sam Charles
Chicago Tribune

"Bully" and "Breezy" are well known in Austin.

Both men are from the area, and both work for the Institute for Nonviolence Chicago, one of the city's street outreach organizations aimed at reducing gun deaths.

Bully and Breezy keep busy. Between the two of them they carry at least five cellphones, checking in regularly with a network of colleagues — more natives of Austin, men who've

spent time in prison — who serve as extra eyes and ears, monitoring the entire neighborhood for problems that could lead to violence.

"We're like 'The Avengers,'" Bully — born Marcus Simpson — told the Tribune last week. "We get everybody from every neighborhood to have a little fun and we come together. That's how we got the violence down."

Year over year, gun violence in Chicago has declined sharply — a 29% decline in homicides and a 34% drop in total shootings through mid-September, accord-

ing to CPD. But despite the gains, the city's decades-old struggle with violence was once again thrust into the spotlight this year as President Donald Trump has threatened a National Guard deployment.

Mayor Brandon Johnson — who, with his family, has lived in Austin for more than 15 years — has consistently rejected that idea. His view comes even as Police Department figures show Austin has not seen the same progress as other parts of the city. Since 2022, the level of killings in the neighborhood has kept rela-

tively stagnant.

"If President Trump wants to help make Chicago safer, he can start by releasing the funds for anti-violence programs that have been critical to our work to drive down crime and violence," Johnson said in a statement last month. "Sending in the National Guard would only serve to destabilize our city and undermine our public safety efforts."

Last weekend, at the memorial for slain conservative activist Charlie Kirk, Trump claimed

Turn to Austin, Page 6

Johnson's plan for council falls apart

Mayor had hoped to shuffle members of powerful committees

By Jake Sheridan and A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson's City Council struggles showed up again Thursday, this time in the form of a ticking clock, empty chairs and his inability to pass a council reorganization plan.

The mayor had hoped to shuffle the members who hold the reins of the body's powerful committees. But hours after aldermen were set to meet and vote on the matter, they were still buzzing around City Hall's backrooms — a sign that the deal Johnson wanted was falling apart.

His proposal ultimately never came up for a vote at the council Rules Committee on Thursday as aldermen met for the first time since July to hammer through a backload of policy.

Johnson could not satisfy the thorniest question in Chicago politics, posed this time by the council's Black Caucus and Latino Caucus: "Where's mine?"

The mayor had planned to give five aldermen various promotions to fill holes left by the retirement of his close ally, former Ald. Walter Burnett Jr. But the fragile lineup his administration had tried to sell aldermen on Wednesday fell apart, leaving dozens of spectators in the City Council chambers waiting for hours as negotiations continued, to no avail, up on the fifth floor.

Asked if he knew why Johnson's team delayed the reorganization plan, Ald. Scott Waguespack, 32nd, offered a short analysis: "They don't know what's going on."

Walking toward the City Council chambers with his Black Caucus colleagues, Ald. Jason Ervin, 28th, struck a more hopeful tone. "The wine is boiling," he said.

When aldermen finally began meeting, they quickly and unceremoniously approved the appointment of Walter "Red" Burnett to

Turn to Council, Page 7

US Border Patrol boats spotted on Chicago River

U.S. Customs and Border Protection agents, including Border Patrol Sector Chief Greg Bovino, in the bow, head east along the Chicago River toward Lake Michigan on Thursday. Four CBP boats were spotted traveling on the river before they docked near the Chicago Harbor Lock as part of a plan to stage marine vessels and vehicles at the facility near Navy Pier. Chicagoland, Page 3

ANTONIO PEREZ/
CHICAGO TRIBUNE



Bailey launches 2nd bid for governor with new strategy

Former state senator hopes to connect better with Chicago voters

By Jeremy Gorner, Rick Pearson and Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

CARTERVILLE, Ill. — Former state Sen. Darren Bailey on Thursday acknowledged that when he ran unsuccessfully for governor against Democrat JB Pritzker nearly four years ago, he didn't understand the issues

affecting Chicago and its suburbs like he did in other parts of the state.

That experience has set the stage for what appears to be a unique campaign structure for the wealthy farmer from southeastern Illinois as he kicked off a relaunch of his bid for governor with a suburban Chicago running mate, Aaron Del Mar, who plans to focus on helping Bailey win over voters in the northern most populous areas of the state while the candidate at the top of the

Turn to Bailey, Page 2

